CHAPTER 21

HURT

21 April 2007

WEST INDIES vs ENGLAND, 2007 World Cup, Super Eights, *Bridgetown*, *Barbados*

England won by 1 wicket (1 ball remaining)

The finger is really sore. I've tried not to tell anyone because I know what they'll say; they'll say I need to go home. The stress fracture and meeting Daniella is now worn into my system, the adolescent daydream of just playing cricket is almost gone. It is not enough any more to simply be playing, mute and awestruck by it all. I feel a desperation now to succeed, to hold on, to be part of something. Anyone who tries to take any opportunity away from me – whether they be staff thinking of my best interests or otherwise – is going to get 'The Look'. It's dawning on me that there are so many more reasons that a career can go wrong than right. If I don't wrest my career into my hands, like a dog with a stick, unwilling to pass it up, I will be chasing it around, back to the same spot I retrieved it from, forever. I have decided to grasp what is in front of me and not let it go. I know what they will say when they see my finger: they will say it's broken. I can already feel that it is broken and yet I am prepared to suffer the pain in silence if it just means I can play on.

We're at the 2007 World Cup in the West Indies. The catch had been to my right. There was such a cruel lack of time between the decision to take off for the ball, being at full stretch, suspended in the air, then feeling it cannon off the tip of my finger, then the pain. The pain is nothing but a nuisance. I know immediately that something has happened that is going to hinder me from playing. There's nothing I hate more in the world than that.